

Read: Luke 1:39-55

Hurry to Be With Other Believers!

Luke 1:39-42

At that time Mary got ready and hurried to a town in the hill country of Judea, where she entered Zechariah's home and greeted Elizabeth. When Elizabeth heard Mary's greeting, the baby leaped in her womb, and Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit. In a loud voice she exclaimed: "Blessed are you among women, and blessed is the child you will bear!"

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Mary hurried to a town in the hill country of Judea. Why was she in such a hurry? The angel Gabriel had just told her that she would give birth to the Savior, Jesus, but he wouldn't be born right away. He still had to grow for many more months until he was ready to be born. So why was Mary in such a hurry to get to this town in Judea?

The answer comes in her relative Elizabeth's greeting. When Mary gets to Elizabeth's house and says hello, something happens. "The baby leaped in her womb, and Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit. In a loud voice, she starts praising God and telling Mary how blessed she is. "Wow," she says, "You are blessed, and your child is blessed—he will be the Savior! And I am blessed because you're visiting me! And the baby growing in my womb is blessed—he's jumping for joy because Jesus is near!"

Mary hurried to Elizabeth because she needed to hear words just like that.

Think of the other words Mary had been hearing back in her hometown. Words from people around her, from family, from the devil, and from her own doubting mind. "Virgins can't become pregnant. Mary is lying. Mary did something wrong." She hurried away from that to be with a fellow believer. Someone who wouldn't think she was crazy and shared the same faith as her in God's promises.

God gives us other believers, too. All around the world, there are people who think we are crazy for believing in a virgin birth. The devil always tries to get us to doubt that Jesus is our Savior. Our sinful hearts can doubt God's promises. What should we do?

Hurry! Run to be with other believers. Get together with people who will praise God and tell you how blessed you are to believe what so many people don't. Say to them as they say to you, "Wow! You are blessed! The child born to Mary is your Savior, too! Blessed are those who believe that!"

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- Who were Mary and Elizabeth?
- Elizabeth's baby leaped in her belly when Jesus was close. Who would that baby grow up to be? (John the Baptist)

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Why did Mary hurry to visit Elizabeth?
- Why do we hurry to be with other believers at church?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- What do you think it means to be "blessed" by God? Do you consider yourself "blessed"?
- Consider a way you can encourage a fellow believer like Elizabeth encouraged Mary.

Closing Prayer:

Fill me, Holy Spirit, with joy knowing Jesus is near! Bless me and my family as we gather with people to sing praise this Christmas. Amen.